

FLORENCE FENNEL

Foeniculum vulgare var. *azoricum*

If you can provide Florence fennel with the conditions it needs it makes a wonderful garden plant—the crisp, swollen stems have a mild aniseed flavor and are good cooked or shredded raw, while the attractive feathery foliage can also be used as a herb. It grows best, and is less likely to bolt, where the weather is cool and nights are mild and short.

	SPRING	SUMMER	FALL	WINTER
SOW				
HARVEST				

SOWING

Before sowing or planting out, prepare the site by digging in well-rotted manure or compost and adding a balanced fertilizer. Florence fennel prefers well-drained, sandy soil, which may need liming if its pH is too acidic.

It is best to sow seed directly into the ground in early summer, although seedlings can be sown from as early as spring under cover or in a greenhouse, or outside if you choose a bolt-resistant variety and protect it with a cloche or cold frame.

If you are sowing under cover, place three seeds into each small pot or module, and thin out as soon as they are strong enough to be handled. Plant them out as soon as the roots can bind the soil.



Harvest once the bulbs are fully formed.

Plants will need to be spaced about 12 in (30 cm) apart, so if sowing directly into the ground, sow several seeds where each plant is to grow and then thin out the weakest as seedlings develop.

CROP CARE

If plants are subjected to too much heat or too little water they are prone to bolting, so it is essential to give them plenty of